

BEFORE

Before the rise of Rome, Italy was inhabited by several cultural groups. One of these was a Latin-speaking people who settled in villages, including Rome, in the hills above the Tiber River in about 1000 BCE.

EARLY DAYS

In the 8th century BCE, the highly developed Etruscan civilization flourished and spread across much of Italy; the Greeks established city-states in southern Italy and Sicily << 94–95; the Latin communities became more complex and Rome began to take shape as an important city.



ETRUSCAN RIDERS

THE BIRTH OF ROME

The date 753 BCE is traditionally given for the founding of the city of Rome. In legend,

Romulus and Remus, twin brothers who were suckled by a she-wolf as babies, founded Rome. Romulus was also the name of the city's first king.



ROMULUS AND REMUS



The Rise of Rome

Ancient Roman civilization arose from multicultural beginnings, while Rome itself began life as a group of villages on the hills above the Tiber River. From these foundations arose the powerful Roman Republic, whose influence and territories spread around the world, with the great city of Rome at its heart.

INVENTION

THE ARCH

The Romans did not invent the arch, but they took its structural possibilities to entirely new levels. They became adept at working with the form and related structures such as the vault and dome, to help support monumental temples, amphitheaters, walls, aqueducts, viaducts, tunnels, lighthouses, and watermills. The Pons Aemilius (below) is the oldest stone bridge across the Tiber River in Rome, and dates from the 2nd century BCE.



By 600 BCE, Rome had become a sophisticated city-state ruled by kings. It boasted specialized crafts, a rich aristocracy, monumental buildings, and organized social systems. The king ruled alongside a Senate and an Assembly. The Senate was a council of elders composed of the heads of various clans. It had the power to approve or veto the appointment of the king. The Assembly consisted of all male citizens of Rome; citizenship was granted only to those whose parents were native Romans. The Assembly's main function was to grant absolute power to the monarch once the clan leaders approved the candidate for king.

Rome stood at the crossroads of major trade routes connecting Europe with Asia and North Africa. Trade not only generated great commercial wealth for Rome, but also brought the Romans in regular contact with several different cultures, such as the Greeks, from whom the Romans absorbed diverse influences. The Romans' Etruscan neighbors also had a profound effect on Rome, so much so that from the middle of the 6th century BCE the Roman monarchs were Etruscan. The

Etruscans gave the Romans the toga, art, certain religious practices, forms of stone arch (see left), sewage systems, and chariot racing. The Greek influence, often passed on via the Etruscans, was strong in art and architecture (see pp.116–17), philosophy, and science and technology (see pp.104–05). The Etruscans also passed the Greek alphabet to the Romans, who developed it to create the basis for many modern western languages.

Roman engineering

The ancient Romans made considerable advances in building and civil engineering, mainly by clever development of principles obtained from other civilizations they came in contact with. While using fired bricks, tiles, and stone to great effect, they also perfected concrete, developing a form capable of hardening under water. From the 3rd century BCE, Roman builders became the first to use

CARTHAGINIAN GENERAL (247–182 BCE)

HANNIBAL BARCA

Hannibal fought with great valor against the Roman Republic in the Second Punic War (218–201 BCE). He captured the city of Saguntum in Spain, allied to Rome, then advanced on Italy. With Rome blocking the sea routes, Hannibal took 37 elephants and 35,000 men over the Pyrenees and Alps, as shown in this fresco. Despite heavy losses, he won many victories but was defeated at Zama in North Africa. Carthage was destroyed by the Romans, and Hannibal fled to Syria, where he later committed suicide.

